

DALIT ICONS, INDIAN IDOLS

Mayawati is using the state machinery aggressively to imprint Dalit imagery on to the public consciousness

CONTROVERSIAL:
The Ambedkar
Sthal in Lucknow



PANKAJ NANGIA

■ By Subhash Mishra

When Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Mayawati gives out orders, the members of her 50-strong Cabinet simply submit. Her latest diktat to ministers, Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) leaders and party workers is that all government and party posters, banners and arches should carry photographs of no one else but her. This policy of self glorification will soon see statues, portraits and murals of the chief minister dotting the state capital, eclipsing those of national heroes, freedom fighters and martyrs.

In the city of nawabs, royalty is slowly giving way to the lowest of the low. More than 5,000 workers have been sweating it out 24x7 to develop various monuments including the Kanshi Ram Memorial, Kanshi Ram Research Centre, Kanshi Ram Auditorium and Rama Bai Ambedkar Memorial. Then there is the Rs 447-crore Ambedkar Sthal, Mayawati's

dream project in the heart of Lucknow. For her it symbolises Dalit empowerment and social change brought in by the "Bahujan Samaj" wresting political power from the hands of the "Manuwadis". The project was started when she became chief minister for the first time in 1995. In two subsequent, though brief, tenures, she spent more than Rs 125 crore on the Sthal, fuelling rumours of financial irregularities. The project, envisioned and landscaped by artist Satish Gujral initially, had marble statues of Lord Buddha and Bhimrao Ambedkar, a canal—Bhim Ganga—that criss-crossed the lush green stretch of land and high-rising domes.

When Mayawati became chief minister for the fourth time this May, among her early promises was to make the Sthal a world-class building for which a further Rs 322 crore has been pumped in. Now a Delhi-based contractor has been hired to reshape the entire building, rechristened as Dr Bhimrao Ambedkar Samajik



CONCEITED: Mayawati plans to erect several statues of herself